MODULE 1 · KNOW YOUR RIGHTS · CHEATSHEET

Consumer Rights, RTE, Local Government & Job Rights

StreetSmarter : Because no one taught us this stuff www.streetsmarter.in

Four rights and systems that quietly run your daily life, whether you've noticed them or not. This is the condensed version, everything you need to recognise them and use them, none of the padding.

A. Consumer Rights

If you've ever bought something that broke, arrived wrong, or wasn't what the ad promised, this is the law that's actually on your side.

- Your 6 rights: Safety, Information, Choice, to Be Heard, Redressal (compensation or refund), and Consumer Education.
- Keep the basics: bills, receipts, warranty cards, and for pricier online orders, an unboxing video. It's your evidence if something goes wrong.
- Complaint won't get resolved directly with the seller? Call the National Consumer Helpline: 1915, or file online through the e-Jagriti portal.
- For bigger disputes, India has a three-tier system, District, State, and National Consumer Commissions, that can order refunds, replacements, or compensation.

National Consumer Helpline · *file a complaint or call 1915*

B. RTE Act (Right to Education)

The Right to Education Act, 2009 makes school a legal right, not a privilege, for every child aged 6 to 14 in India.

- Free and compulsory education, Class 1 to 8, in a neighbourhood school, government or private.
- Private, unaided schools must reserve 25% of entry-level seats for children from economically weaker and disadvantaged backgrounds, at no cost to the family.
- No capitation fee, no donation, and no screening test or interview is allowed for admission at this level*
- A child cannot be expelled, held back, or denied a certificate of completion until elementary education (up to Class 8) is finished.

*The RTE Act prohibits screening procedures for admission to elementary education (Classes 1–8). However, in practice, many private schools continue to conduct academic assessments for transfer admissions into higher elementary classes, reflecting a gap between the statutory framework and admissions practices.

C. Local Government Structure

The offices that actually fix your street, your water supply, or your local park, not the national government, your local one.

- Rural areas (Panchayati Raj, 73rd Amendment): Gram Panchayat (village level) → Panchayat Samiti (block level) → Zila Parishad (district level).
- Urban areas (74th Amendment): Nagar Panchayat (small town) → Municipal Council / Municipality (mid-sized city) → Municipal Corporation (big city).
- Your local representative: a Sarpanch heads a Gram Panchayat, a Councillor or Corporator represents your ward in a city, and a Mayor heads a Municipal Corporation.
- These bodies handle roads, drainage, water supply, garbage collection, and streetlights, the stuff you can actually walk down and see.

D. Minimum Wage & Part-Time Job Rights

If you're thinking about a part-time job or internship, here's what the law actually allows.

- Minimum legal age to work in India: 14 years. Below that, employment is prohibited in any establishment, with limited exceptions like family enterprises after school hours.
- Ages 14 to 18 are legally "adolescents": you can only work non-hazardous jobs, max 6 hours a day (3-hour stretches with a break), never between 7 PM and 8 AM, and never overtime.
- Minimum wage is set separately by each state and revised periodically, so the number differs depending on where you live and the type of work.
- Whatever the job, you're entitled to a wage record or payslip, and any overtime (for adult workers) must legally be paid at double the normal rate.

Useful Links

National Consumer Helpline · *file a consumer complaint or call 1915*

e-Jagriti Portal · *file a case directly with a Consumer Commission*

Right to Education Act overview · *know your RTE admission rights*